Srila Sacchidananda Bhaktivinoda Thakura

Шрила Саччидананда Бхактивинода Тхакур · @bhaktivinoda

Mahaprabhu's envoy

Srila Sacchidananda Bhaktivinoda Thakura (1838–1914) is the acharya with whom, in modern times, the preaching of Sri Chaitanya's pure bhakti began to flow once more. He revealed to the world the place of Mahaprabhu's appearance in Mayapur, left more than a hundred books, and became the father and shiksha-guru of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati. His parents named him Kedarnatha; in government service he was known as Kedarnatha Datta, and one of his early works, the "Sri Chaitanya-gita," he signed with the pen-name Sacchidananda Premalankara. The title "Bhaktivinoda" — "he whose joy is bhakti" — was conferred on him by Vaishnavas, and ever since the Vaishnava world has called him Sri Sacchidananda Bhaktivinoda Thakura. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's followers honour him as Om Vishnupada Srila Thakura Bhaktivinoda Gosvami Prabhu, as Bhaktivinoda Prabhu and as Bhaktivinoda Vibhu.

The pranama-mantra with which he is saluted says: "I bow to Bhaktivinoda, whose name is Sacchidananda, the embodiment of Gaura's potency, the best of the followers of Sri Rupa." And the daily prayer of the Brahma-Madhva-Sarasvata-Gaudiya line says of him: "Sri Bhaktivinoda-deva, the root of the preaching of pure bhakti, the best here, is renowned as the Lord's beloved."

Sri Chaitanya Math, the Gaudiya Maths, Sri Chaitanya Gaudiya Math and their kindred missions owe him everything: he is the root of their daily life. "All that we do is for Sri Krishna-Chaitanya, Sri Rupa, Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura and our gurudeva," Srila Bhaktisiddhanta wrote in one of his letters. On his father's books and teaching he built his mission and began to fulfil Mahaprabhu's prophecy: "In every town and village throughout the world My holy name will be sung" (CB, Antya 4.126). And the Lord's command — "Whomever you meet, instruct him in the science of Krishna. I order you: become guru and deliver this land" (CC, Madhya 7.128) — Srila Bhaktisiddhanta repeated to everyone.

Darkness over Gauda

When Mahaprabhu concealed His pastimes, and after Him Svarupa Damodara, Ramananda Raya and the six Gosvamis departed, and then Srinivasa, Narottama and Shyamananda, darkness gathered over the Lord's teaching. Communities arose that had strayed from His path (apa-sampradayas); Totaram Dasa Babaji counted thirteen of them: the auls, bauls, kartabhajas, neras, darveshes, sais, sahajiyas, sakhibhekis, smartas, jata-gosanis, atibaris, chudadharis and gauranga-nagaris. Seeing them, educated Bengalis came to regard Mahaprabhu's faith as a religion of low and immoral people. Then the Lord in His mercy sent into the world His eternal associate, Bhaktivinoda, to bring such people back to the truth.

"Our Teachers" draws the same picture. Under the influence of Kali-yuga Mahaprabhu's teaching was distorted by false interpretations: pseudo-Vaishnava sects, under the guise of Gaudiya Vaishnavism, glorified worldly enjoyment, while those who wished to defend brahminical culture and dharma forgot the universal ideals of Sri Chaitanya and began to claim caste privileges, passing them down by inheritance in the families of the descendants of Mahaprabhu's first disciples. The very word "Gaudiya Vaishnava" became for educated Indians a synonym for immorality. It was necessary to restore Mahaprabhu's glory and show the world the true greatness of His teaching — and this came about through the outstanding thinker, poet and preacher Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura, who restored the original teaching of the Gaudiya Vaishnavas.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta writes in his preface to the "Jaiva-dharma": Bhaktivinoda is a very intimate associate of Sri Chaitanya-chandra. When the preachers of Chaitanya's cherished desires had left this

world, the sky of Bengal was overcast with clouds of sensuality and false renunciation; and almost three hundred and fifty years after Mahaprabhu's appearance Bhaktivinoda came to light up the sky of Gauda once more. All the qualities of a Vaishnava of which the "Chaitanya-charitamrita" speaks were perfectly manifest in his life: "Vaishnavas are merciful, humble, always truthful, impartial, faultless, magnanimous and soft-hearted" (CC, Madhya 22.75). And the mercy that Gaura-Hari distributed in nine ways can be seen in his life and in his works.

Outwardly he was a householder and a government official — and yet he wrote more than a hundred books in several languages. In them he refuted views opposed to Mahaprabhu's teaching, and through them many throughout the world came to recognise the worth of that teaching; Vaishnavas accept his every word as shastra. Vyasa found peace only when he had described Krishna's pastimes in the "Bhagavata," and Mahaprabhu preached the religion of the "Bhagavata"; but after the departure of His associates the path of bhakti became overgrown with thorns — until Bhaktivinoda, by his books, laid bare the emptiness of the false doctrines. Such preaching is impossible without power given by Krishna: he is a direct associate of Gauranga and of Krishna.

Lineage

The Lord's eternal associates, descending for the sake of the fallen, behave like human beings: they may even live as householders, yet maya does not touch or bind them, for their hearts are attached to the Lord. Only those surrendered to Vishnu and the Vaishnavas can discern this. So too Bhaktivinoda's life in family and in service was not worldly.

His family traces its descent to the kayastha Purushottama — one of the brahmanas and noble Hindus whom King Adishura invited to Bengal. Purushottama's descendants in the seventh and eighth generations, Vinayaka and Narayana, were ministers, and in the fifteenth generation lived a contemporary of Mahaprabhu, Raja Krishnananda Datta, a devotee of Krishna. Sri Nityananda Prabhu stayed in his house with His party and blessed him generously[1].

A descendant of Krishnananda, Govinda Sharan Datta, founded the village of Govindapur; Kalighat, Sutanuti and Govindapur became the core of Calcutta. Govinda Sharan's grandson was Ramachandra; Ramachandra's grandson was Madan Mohan Datta, who gave Calcutta the Hedua-pukur tank and in 1774 built at his own cost the steps at Pretashira in Gaya and on Chandranath hill. His grandson was Rajavallabha Datta, and Rajavallabha's son was Ananda Chandra Datta, Bhaktivinoda's father, a deeply pious and detached man. His mother, Jaganmohini Devi, was the daughter of Ishvara Chandra Mustaufi, a well-known zamindar of the village of Ula in the Nadia district. The Dattas were a family of kayasthas; in Calcutta there is still a place called Hatkhola Datta, named after this family, and the large village of Ula near Birnagar belonged to his mother's family, the Mustaufis, well-known landowners.

Appearance and childhood

Srila Bhaktivinoda appeared in 1838, on the Gaura-trayodashi of the month of Hrishikesha, in Ula-Birnagar (Nadia district), in the house of his maternal grandfather[2].

He composed his first poem at the age of two. His songs were not the fruit of worldly talent: in an eternally perfect associate of the Lord they manifested of themselves. At six he knew the "Mahabharata" and the "Ramayana" in every detail.

In his "Autobiography" he recalls that at nine he took up astrology, but at ten gave it up to seek spiritual truth and began to ask people about their convictions — without ever offending anyone. For from birth he was established in the truth and only enacted these pastimes to show what is special about human life.

As a boy he went to festivals; he also visited a tantric brahmachari who kept a human skull — and gave the skull water to see whether it would "smile." The skull did not smile. He asked the old craftsman who painted the backdrop for an image of Durga when the goddess enters the image; neither at the "painting of the eyes" nor at the rite of consecration did the boy notice it, and the craftsman admitted that he himself believed only in the one Supreme, Parameshvara[3]. The treasury guard, a Muslim named Golam Khan, told him the Muslim account of creation — "Rama and Rahim are one, it is Khoda" — and taught him a charm against ghosts. His maternal uncle Parashuram Mustaufi, a student of law, lost his faith in God and called Rammohan Roy his guru; other uncles, Raghu and Nashu, followed him. This troubled the boy, and the answer of a certain bhattacharya confused him still more; but he did not give up the name of Rama.

The lesson of these childhood searchings is simple: instead of speculating about God and the world, one should chant the Holy Name with faith. So too Mahaprabhu, tying up His books, told His students only to sing the Name.

Studies and marriage

At six he was sent to learn Sanskrit at the tol of Vidyavachaspati, and at seven his grandfather sent him to the Krishnanagar College[4]: its principal was Captain D. L. Richardson, its chief Indian professor Ramtanu Lahiri, and one of his fellow students the young Raja of Cooch Behar. A year later an English school opened in Ula, and the boy moved there.

When he was eleven his father died. As was the custom of the time, his mother married her twelve-year-old son to a five-year-old girl from neighbouring Ranaghat. He himself later called it a "doll's wedding": when he visited his mother-in-law, a nurse was sent with him.

After his maternal grandfather's death he and his mother moved to Calcutta, to the family house at the corner of Beadon Street and Hedua[5]. There he studied at the Hindu Charitable Trust school, and four years later, in 1856, entered the Hindu School. He was one of the first pupils of Ishvara Chandra Vidyasagara, who loved him. Once the teacher said that it was better not to speak of God, Whom no one has seen. Kedarnatha objected: why then is it written in the "Bodhodaya" that God is formless? The Almighty can also have form; the Lord is the eternal master and I am His eternal servant, and natural love for Him is bhakti, the highest knowledge, brahma-vidya and para-vidya.

In 1856 the University of Calcutta was founded and the first entrance examinations were held. Among his fellow students were Satyendranath and Ganendranath Tagore, Taraknath Palit and Navagopal Mitra; his English was admired by the principal, Clint, by the Reverend Duff, George Thompson and Keshab Chandra Sen. At the end of that year he published an English poem, "The Poriade"; his English verses appeared in the "Literary Gazette," and at the British Indian Society he lectured on the evolution of matter. He studied Brahmo-dharma, Christianity, the Bible, the Koran and other teachings; he placed Christianity above Brahmoism, because it acknowledges the eternal personality of God. In the year of the Sepoy Rising, 1857, he travelled and lectured.

He was exceptionally gifted and well known in intellectual circles. In time he drew close to the "Brahmo Samaj" — the society of Rammohan Roy's followers — and his closest friend became Dvijendranath Tagore, of the family of Maharshi Debendranath Tagore.[6]

A grandfather's prophecy and first employment

In 1858 he set out from Bengal for Nilachala. At Chhutigram he visited his grandfather, Krishnavallabha Datta; the old man foretold that his grandson would become a great Vaishnava — and at once left his body, the life-air departing through the crown of his head. In Puri Kedarnatha attended

the Chandana-yatra of Jagannatha, stayed on for a few more days, and returned to Calcutta by way of Cuttack, Bhadrak and Midnapore[7].

On Vidyasagara's recommendation he became a teacher at the government secondary school in Cuttack, and soon, in 1860, headmaster of the school at Bhadrak. In those years he wrote a book on the monasteries of Orissa, "Maths of Orissa," which Sir William Hunter drew on extensively in his work "Orissa," and the "Sri Chaitanya-gita," signed with the name Sacchidananda Premalankara.

He also taught in Midnapore. There a speech of his on true religion, given at a literary society, deeply moved a member of the Brahmo Samaj, Rama Narayana Basu. In Midnapore his first wife died, and in a second marriage he wed Bhagavati Devi.

From Midnapore he moved to Burdwan and preached there too. In 1863 his English book "Our Wants" came out. In Burdwan the Brahmos and the Christians were in dispute, and he tried to reconcile them: in two lectures he showed the weakness of both sides' arguments. He founded a circle, the "Bhratri-samaja," where his talk on the soul attracted a certain Mr. Haley. Then service took him to Chuadanga and Ranaghat, and for a time to Chhapra in Bihar; from there he made his first journey to Vrindavana, by train, through Kashi, Mirzapur, Prayag and Agra. In Chhapra he learned Urdu and Persian and gave a lecture on Gautama.

From Chhapra he was transferred to Purnea, and in 1868 to Dinajpur as Deputy Magistrate. There the Hindus were in dispute with the Brahmos, and he answered both sides with a speech, "The Bhagavata: Its Philosophy, Its Ethics and Its Theology." The "Brahmo Samaj" had placed great hopes in him — an educated and gifted man of letters, able to conduct a debate at a high level; but his study of the "Srimad-Bhagavatam" made the break inevitable, and this lecture at Dinajpur showed everyone that he was parting with the followers of Rammohan Roy and embracing the Vaishnava teaching as Sriman Mahaprabhu preached it. In June of that year he visited the house of Sri Rupa and Sri Sanatana at Ramakeli, and Rajmahal. Returning to Calcutta, he searched long for copies of the "Chaitanya-charitamrita" and the "Srimad-Bhagavatam" and at last found them with the publishers of Bat-tala.

Five years in Puri

With these books he went to Purushottama-dhama: the government entrusted him with supervising the management of Lord Jagannatha's temple. From 1869 to 1874 he lived in Puri without a break. It is said of a Vaishnava that he is "softer than a flower and harder than a thunderbolt" — and such was Bhaktivinoda: kind to all, he would not tolerate deceit cloaked in the name of religion. As inspector of Jagannatha's temple he fought against dishonest servants who profited by the religious feelings of the faithful.

In 1871, on the edge of the forest near Bhubaneswar, there lived with his disciples a yogi named Bishikishan, of the Khandait caste and the Atibari sect. Having gained mystic powers, he proclaimed himself an incarnation of Mahavishnu and announced in Oriya verses that on the 14th of the month of Chaitra (in the verses — the thirteenth month, Mina) he would assume a four-armed form and destroy the foreign mlecchas. He cured incurable diseases and gathered a great many followers. At last he announced that at the full moon he would perform a "rasa-lila," and summoned the girls of a neighbouring village. The Chaudhuris of the Bhringar clan, whose women he had defiled, complained to the district commissioner, Mr. Ravenshaw, and he entrusted the investigation to Bhaktivinoda.

Bhaktivinoda went into the forest himself. Bishikishan called himself the living Mahavishnu and blasphemed Lord Jagannatha, while trying to flatter Bhaktivinoda. Seeing that the impostor would not give up his deceit, Bhaktivinoda arrested him and brought him to Puri. He gathered evidence in the

surrounding villages and in the Buddhist viharas near Khandagiri. During the trial the yogi sent illnesses upon him and his family, but could not intimidate him: for conspiracy to rebellion Bhaktivinoda sentenced him to eighteen months' imprisonment. For twenty-one days Bishikishan neither ate nor drank — and left his body. In the months that followed Bhaktivinoda put an end to the deceit of two more impostors: an "incarnation of Brahma" in Jajpur and a "manifestation of Balarama" in Khurda.

The "Bhagavata-samsad"

In Puri he immersed himself in the shastras: he studied the "Bhagavata," the six "Sandarbhas" of Srila Jiva Gosvami, the "Govinda-bhashya," "Siddhanta-ratna" and "Prameya-ratnavali" of Srila Baladeva Vidyabhushana, and — in particular detail — Srila Rupa's "Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu"; thus he showed how necessary the study of scripture is. He also studied the "Chaitanya-charitamrita" and Narahari Chakravarti's "Bhakti-ratnakara," while he did not accept Jayananda's "Chaitanya-mangala" as authoritative. Here he wrote the Sanskrit "Datta-kaustubha" and began the Sanskrit verses of the "Sri Krishna-samhita."

For the regular study of the "Bhagavata" he founded an assembly, the "Bhagavata-samsad," in the Jagannatha-vallabha garden; prominent Vaishnavas of Puri came to hear him — Nityananda Dasa, Paramananda Dasa, Narayana Dasa Mahanta, and Harihara Dasa Mahanta of Uttara-parshva. For with Mahaprabhu hearing the "Bhagavata" is one of the five principal limbs of bhakti, and Srila Jiva calls it the best of them. As Mahaprabhu heard the "Bhagavata" from Gadadhara Pandita, so Bhaktivinoda heard it from Sri Gopinatha Pandita.

Not everyone was pleased. A babaji, Raghunatha Dasa of the Hati-akhra, objected to his readings — and fell ill; but Lord Jagannatha told him in a dream to go to Bhaktivinoda and beg forgiveness, and when he had done so he recovered. In Jagannatha's temple Bhaktivinoda would not sit in the Mukti-mandapa, where the mayavadis debated, but spoke near the temple of Lakshmi, where the footprints of Mahaprabhu are kept. His talks drew many mayavadis too, and the place came to be called the Bhakti-mandapa — the Bhakti-prangana. He also kept company with the siddha Vaishnava Svarupa Dasa Babaji, discussing the shastras with him.

The family lived near Grand Road, beside Narayana-chhata, not far from the temple, in a house on land that a wealthy family leased from the Dakshina-parshva Math. In 1974 Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava Gosvami Maharaja recovered this house, and today Sri Chaitanya Gaudiya Math stands there with a beautiful temple.

The birth of Bimala Prasada

Srila Bhaktivinoda prayed fervently to the Lord for a son who would continue the work of his life — the preaching of Sri Chaitanya's teaching in all its beauty and depth — and the Lord fulfilled this prayer.

In this house, on Friday 6 February 1874, on the krishna-panchami of the month of Magha, at half past three in the afternoon, a son was born to Bhagavati Devi — the future Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati, the fourth child of the family. The Thakura and the household were singing the holy names at that time. The umbilical cord was wound about the infant's body like a sacred thread. His father named him Bimala Prasada, after Vimala Devi, the potency of Lord Jagannatha; the child's first solid food was maha-prasada[8].

Six months later, at the Ratha-yatra, Lord Jagannatha's chariot by His will stopped before Bhaktivinoda's house at Narayana-chhata and stood there three days; for all three days, at the Thakura's direction, kirtana never ceased. Bhagavati Devi, the baby in her arms, went up onto the chariot, and, stretching out his little hand, he touched Jagannatha's feet and received His garland; the pandas foretold

a great future for the boy. As he grew, he listened attentively to the "Bhagavata" from his father's lips[9].

Bhaktivinoda was "Jagannatha's own man": by His arrangement he was brought to Puri to set His service in order. And after Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's birth Mahaprabhu's message spread throughout the world; thus are interpreted the words of the "Padma Purana," "from Purushottama in Utkala." Ten months after his son's birth Bhaktivinoda was transferred to Ranaghat, and the family returned to Bengal overland, in palanquins.

Travels and preaching

From 1877 to 1910 Bhaktivinoda travelled all over India as a pilgrim and preacher. First he visited Amta (Uluberia subdivision), the shripata of Abhirama Thakura at Khanakul-Krishnanagar, Shyampur, Bhadrak, Naral (Jessore district), Calcutta and Prayag, and then Vrindavana, Radha-kunda and Govardhana. Near Govardhana he scattered a gang of Kanjhar robbers who were plundering pilgrims. The way back led through Mathura, Lucknow, Faizabad, Guptar-ghat, Ayodhya and Benares.

It was then, in Vrindavana, in 1880, that he first bowed at the feet of Srila Jagannatha Dasa Babaji and received from him many instructions on hari-bhakti[10]. From 1885 he often received spiritual guidance from the Babaji; their mutual attraction, Vaishnavas say, was "from time immemorial."

In Calcutta he began building his house, the "Bhakti Bhavana." When the foundations were being dug, a Deity of Sri Kurmadeva emerged from the earth; Bhaktivinoda gave Him to his seven-year-old son and taught him His worship — the mantra of Kurma — and from then on the boy wore tilaka[11]. At this time too Bhaktivinoda first visited Mayapur.

In his service he was Deputy Collector in the Barasat subdivision, and then he was transferred from place to place: Srirampur (1884), Vaidyanath, Bankipur, Gaya — where he saw the steps at Pretashira built by his ancestor Madan Mohan Datta[12] — again Naral and Barasat, Memari, Kulinagrama, Bandel and Saptagram. In Kulinagrama he lectured on the Holy Name, distinguishing the pure name, namabhasa — the shadow of the name — and namaparadha, offensive chanting. There too he gave his son initiation into harinama and the Nrisimha-mantra[13]. Once, returning from Puri, he gave his son, then a pupil in the seventh class, a tulasi-mala of Lord Jagannatha, and read to him the "Sri Chaitanya-shikshamrita," which he was writing at the time.

In 1885 he founded in Calcutta the "Chaitanya-yantra" press, and in the "Bhakti Bhavana" a publishing house, the "Vaishnava Depository." His son helped him with the printing and proof-reading and travelled with him to the shripatas — to Kulinagrama and Saptagram — hearing his lectures on the Holy Name. In those same years the Sri Gaudiya Gosvami-sangha, for the four-hundredth anniversary of Mahaprabhu's appearance, conferred on him the title "Bhaktivinoda"[14].

In 1885, 399 years after Mahaprabhu's appearance, he founded in the house of Rama Gopala Basu, in its Durga-mandapa in Krishna-Singher Gali off Bethune Road, the "Vishva-vaishnava-sabha" — the "World Society of Vaishnavas" — to preach Vaishnavism, in the words of "Our Teachers," in all the countries of the world; it is also called the "Vishva-vaishnava-raja-sabha," the "royal assembly of the Vaishnavas of the whole world"[15]. Among its members were Madana Gopala Gosvami, Nilakantha Gosvami, Bipin Bihari Gosvami, Radhikanatha Gosvami and Shishir Kumar Ghosh. The Thakura lectured there on the "Chaitanya-charitamrita" and the "Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu," and every Sunday his son went with him to the meetings and carried his father's "Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu" for him. A year later, in 1886, the society celebrated the four-hundredth anniversary of Mahaprabhu's appearance. This sabha, tradition says, was first founded by Srila Jiva Gosvami eleven years after Mahaprabhu's departure; Bhaktivinoda gave it new life, and Srila Bhaktisiddhanta revived it in 1919 (of which more below). In those years Bhaktivinoda also met the famous Ramakrishna Paramahamsa, refuted his

impersonalism and explained to him the truth of pure bhakti.

The mentor

Srila Jagannatha Dasa Babaji, the "general of the Vaishnavas," Srila Bhaktivinoda honoured as his mentor. In his song on the chain of teachers Srila Bhaktisiddhanta remembers "Jagannatha, whose dear disciple is Bhaktivinoda." The Babaji, like him, was a goshthyanandi — one who rejoices in the company of devotees and makes the community grow; and his wish to see the sampradaya and its preaching flourish blossomed and bore fruit in Bhaktivinoda. The Babaji inspired him to preach the name and the dhama of Gaura, and verses in the Babaji's praise say that he invested all his power in his devotee Bhaktivinoda and through him sent the stream of harinama over the world; the blessed line of Bhaktivinoda grew from his body and his labours.

Where the Lord appeared

In 1887 Bhaktivinoda visited Tarakeshwar, the chief Shiva-linga of Bengal. There Lord Shiva said to him in a dream: "You long for Vrindavana, but close to you is Navadvipa-dhama, where so much remains to be done. What have you done there?" In the same year he was transferred to Krishnanagar, a few miles from Navadvipa. He began to visit Kulia — the present town of Navadvip — and stayed at the Ranir Dharmashala above the Ganga. One evening at about ten o'clock, standing on the roof, he saw across the river a shining building; the light was seen also by his son Kamala Prasada, who was with him.

Bhaktivinoda learned that the light came from a place by the Ballal-dighi, and the old men of that village confirmed: here Mahaprabhu was born. Having studied old maps and documents, he established firmly that the place of the Lord's appearance lies by the Ballal-dighi. He examined the "Bhakti-ratnakara," the government's old statistical and topographical maps and the records of the district court, and laid the evidence before an assembly of the district's leading men and the famous pandits of Navadvipa — and they approved it.

"Our Teachers" tells of this discovery as follows.[16] Formerly the place of the Lord's appearance was thought to lie by the market square in Navadvipa; but having studied the works of Srila Narahari Chakravarti Thakura and Sri Paramananda Prabhu and several eighteenth-century maps, the Thakura came to doubt this. One night he saw a wondrous radiance a few miles north of his house; in the morning he went there, asking the inhabitants along the way, and came to a broad mound thickly overgrown with tulasi. Thus the true site of Jagannatha Mishra's house was found.

In 1888 he bought a plot in Godruma-dvipa and named it Surabhi-kunja; from Krishnanagar he also visited his native Ula. In 1889 he was transferred to the Netrokona subdivision of Mymensingh district, in East Bengal; he visited Narayanganj, the town of Mymensingh, the Garo hills, where he blessed the Hajong people, and Goalundo. Then came transfers to Tangail and Burdwan, and journeys to Shantipur, Kalna, Bagnapara, Koigram and Denur, the shripata of Srila Vrindavana Dasa Thakura.

In May 1890 he was again in Kulia and visited Jagannatha Dasa Babaji in his bhajana-kutira in Koladvipa, where the Babaji spent his last years. In service to him Bhaktivinoda added a concrete veranda to the kutira[17]. From Burdwan he went to sing kirtana with the devotees of the village of Amlajora, and visited Gopalpur, Raniganj and Barakar. In 1890 he served at Raniganj, in 1891 at Dinajpur.

In Calcutta he met Shishir Kumar Ghosh, a newspaper publisher. Ghosh regarded him as his guru and called him "the seventh Gosvami," was a constant visitor to the "Bhakti Bhavana," and at his word began to chant japa and wear a tulasi-mala, but was never able to adopt the Vaishnava way of life

completely. Bhaktivinoda visited Midnapore, where he spoke with Sitanatha Mohapatra and others, Ghatal and Kayapat-Badna-ganj in Hooghly, and returned to Krishnanagar, to Surabhi-kunja. In Krishnanagar he convened large meetings, regularly attended by Englishmen too — Malrow, Wallace, Butler.

On 9 March 1892, at Amlajora, in the presence of Jagannatha Dasa Babaji, he observed Hari-vasara — ekadashi; all night long there was kirtana and talk of Krishna. A "Prapanna-ashrama" was being established there — a place for hearing hari-katha and singing kirtana. The Thakura himself wrote of that day in the "Sajjana-toshani": after the ekadashi vigil, at eight in the morning, the whole village came out for nagara-sankirtana and moved towards the Prapanna-ashrama; at its head went the Babaji, who was over a hundred years old[18]. He danced "like a lion" and sang: "What a name Nitai has brought! He has brought it to the market of the Name and gives it for faith" ("nitai ki nama enechhe re…"); he wept and fell in ecstasy, and all shed tears, all trembled, and, scarcely able to sing, all danced. In his dance the Babaji rose up in rapture, watered the ground with his tears, and for a long time lost external consciousness. The Thakura in his hari-katha spoke of how necessary such abodes are, and the Babaji declared the ashrama open; he rejoiced at the Thakura's zeal in preaching the name[19].

From Amlajora Bhaktivinoda went via Buxar and Prayag to Vrindavana, and from 21 to 29 March went round Vraja: Bilvavana, Bhandiravana, Mathavana, Man-sarovara, Mathura, Gokula, Madhuvana, Talavana, Kumudavana, Bahulavana, Radha-kunda, Govardhana and other places; he returned through Cawnpore and Allahabad. In Calcutta he preached in the "Bhakti Bhavana" and continued the meetings in Krishnanagar. In the same year, 1892, the Babaji with the Vaishnavas sang sankirtana in Godruma, and then in Mayapur.

In the month of Magha 1299 of the Bengali era (February 1893) the Babaji came from Kulia to Godruma, to Surabhi-kunja: with his companions he crossed the Ganga, and the whole neighbourhood resounded with kirtana. On Wednesday, 27 Magha, Bhaktivinoda held a kirtana festival, and the Babaji was its guest of honour. From then on the Thakura often came to the Babaji, and the Babaji visited the Thakura both in Godruma and in Calcutta.

And on Thursday, 20 Phalguna of the same year (March 1893)[20], the Thakura came to the Babaji in the morning with kirtana, and at eleven o'clock the devotees crossed with him to Mayapur in three boats. The Babaji was carried in a palanquin; usually the old man was carried in a basket by his servant, the Vrajavasi Bihari Dasa. At the place of appearance Dvarika Babu awaited them with kirtana and flags. The Babaji led everyone to the birthplace of the Lord — the Yogapitha — began to dance and pointed it out exactly, and then struck that very spot several times hard with his staff, to dispel all doubt. He also pointed out Khola-bhangar-danga — Srivasa-angana. They danced there as no one had danced in Navadvipa for almost four hundred years. It was decided to begin the service of Deities at the place of appearance and at Srivasa-angana: the Babaji proposed to install Jagannatha Mishra and Shachi in one building, in another Mahaprabhu with Lakshmi and Vishnupriya at His sides, and at Srivasa-angana the Pancha-tattva.

According to "Our Teachers," the Thakura called the Babaji, his guru, to verify the discovery. The old man could no longer walk by himself, and a disciple carried him in a basket; but on seeing the place of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu's appearance the Babaji leapt out of the basket and broke into dance, rejoicing and calling out the names of Sri Gaura. After that no doubt remained. The great joy that filled him the Thakura expressed in the "Sri Navadvipa-dhama-mahatmya" (according to other biographies it appeared earlier, in 1887–1890; see below), where he told of events revealed to him: the book describes Srila Jiva Gosvami's pilgrimage through the holy places of Navadvipa-mandala under the guidance of Sri Nityananda Prabhu.

At about that time Bhaktivinoda argued with a descendant of a gosvami family who regarded one of Mahaprabhu's closest associates as a shudra. Grieved, the Thakura answered him with a verse, "vaishnava-charitra sarvada pavitra…": the character of a Vaishnava is always pure, and with one who out of envy reviles a Vaishnava Bhaktivinoda does not speak — he keeps silent. He wrote out his chain of teachers (guru-parampara) and hung it outside the "Bhakti Bhavana." He also preached in Bihar — at Sasaram, Nasirganj and Dehri.

In January 1894, at a large meeting in the A.B. School in Krishnanagar, it was resolved to install Deities at the place of appearance, and the "Navadvipa-pracharini-sabha" was founded to spread word of this place far and wide; its secretary was Naphar Chandra Pal Bhaktibhushana, zamindar of Natudaha (Nadia). Dvarika Babu, Naphar Babu and others decided to put up a thatched hut there for the Deities of Gaura and Vishnupriya.

The Deities were installed on 21 March 1894 (9 Chaitra 1300 of the Bengali era), on Phalguni-purnima — Gaura-purnima — during a lunar eclipse, amid loud kirtana[21]. Thus Bhaktivinoda, following Srila Narottama, who installed Gaura and Vishnupriya at Kheturi, with the permission of Jagannatha Dasa Babaji manifested the service of Gaurasundara with Vishnupriya in Gaura's house in Mayapur. By this he answered the teachings which, calling themselves worship of Vishnupriya-Gauranga, reject the path of the rupanugas: the "gaura-bhajis," "gauravadis," gauranga-nagaris and blends with theosophy. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta sang of it in a song: Bhaktivinoda, servant of Gaura, remembering Narottama's feet, installed Priya and Hari in Mayapur. Through him the Babaji also revealed to the world once more the day of Srimati Vishnupriya's appearance — Sri-panchami, the shukla-panchami of the month of Magha; from Bhaktivinoda this custom spread throughout the Vaishnava world.

For the service of the Deities the "Sri Mayapur-seva-samiti" was formed. Its members were Shyamlal Gosvami, Shashibhushan Gosvami, Radhikanatha Gosvami, Bipina Bihari Gosvami, Mahamahopadhyaya Ajitanatha Nyayaratna, Mahendranatha Bhattacharya Vidyaranya, Satya Jivan Lahiri, Raja Vanamali Ray Bahadur of Tarash (Pabna), Shishir Kumar Ghosh, Matilal Ghosh, Yatindranatha Chaudhuri, Mahendranatha Majumdar, the advocate Kishorilal Sarkar, Nalinaksha Datta, Kanailal Dey Bahadur, the Deputy Magistrate Navin Chandra Sen and Jagatchandra Ray.

According to "Our Teachers," having left government service, the Thakura collected donations for a temple at the place of the Lord's appearance and approached everyone — even those on whom he had once, as a judge, passed sentence; at the same time he preached the Holy Name widely. His efforts were not in vain: with the funds he collected the first building was erected at the holy place of appearance. To care for the dhama and serve it he formed a special committee, and later he entrusted the care of Mayapur to his son.

It was not easy, this book relates, to convince people that the true dhama had been found; moreover, no one lived there at the time. In due course a brick building was put up, where the worship of the Deity of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu began; the real temple was built later. The brahmanas who cooked for the Deity did not wish to stay long in a deserted and unsafe place, and so that the service should not be interrupted, the Thakura went to great lengths: at times he himself prepared ganja for the cook — otherwise the man refused to serve — and he saw to tobacco for "respectable" visitors. For the sake of serving the dhama he had to do much else that does not befit a religious man.[22]

The Babaji also visited Bhaktivinoda in the Calcutta "Bhakti Bhavana," in Ram-Bagan; the Thakura always invited him for prasada, but the detached old man came only rarely. There the Babaji met the twelve-year-old Bimala Prasada and, learning that the boy was versed in jyotisha, told him to compose a Vaishnava calendar reckoned in years from Chaitanya's appearance. So arose the "Navadvipa-panjika," which Sri Chaitanya Math publishes to this day. The Babaji allowed no one to photograph him, but

Bhaktivinoda arranged for a photograph when he was a guest at the "Bhakti Bhavana": this picture — the Babaji on a wooden seat, with Giridhari on his breast — now stands on the altars of the Gaudiya Maths. The Babaji loved Bhaktivinoda deeply and, it is said, gave him his own Giridhari; the Thakura installed this shila in his Calcutta house, and He is served there to this day.

Srila Jagannatha Dasa Babaji entered the eternal pastimes on the shukla-pratipat of the month of Phalguna, Monday 25 February 1895[23]. Bhaktivinoda wrote in the "Sajjana-toshani": at ten in the morning, in his bhajana-kutira in Koladvipa, the old general of the Vaishnavas departed for the eternal abode.

A sweeper in the market of the Name

Srila Bhaktivinoda called himself a sweeper in the market of the Holy Name, and in one of his prayers he asks for one thing only: to be a broom in the nama-hatta — the market of the Name — of Sri Nityananda. Such was the spirit of all his preaching: meetings, lectures on the pure name and on offences, abodes like the "Prapanna-ashrama" at Amlajora, where people hear hari-katha and sing kirtana.

A message for the whole world

Srila Bhaktivinoda foretold that prema-dharma, the religion of divine love, is so beautiful that every reasonable person will surely accept it, for the teaching that true religion is selfless love of God must be recognised as the highest of theistic teachings. The free-thinking people of the West, he said, will certainly accept the idea of divine love that Sri Chaitanyadeva brought. Such was his firm conviction, and he spoke of it constantly in the lectures he gave all over Bengal. In 1885 he wrote in the "Sajjana-toshani":

"Lord Chaitanya did not descend to save a chosen few in India. No. His chief aim was the deliverance of all living beings in all the countries of the world and the preaching of the eternal religion, sanatana-dharma. In the 'Chaitanya Bhagavata' these words of the Lord are given: 'In every town, country and village My Name will be sung.' There can be no doubt that the time has come for this prophecy to be fulfilled. Very soon the unequalled path of Harinama-sankirtana will be proclaimed all over the world… Oh, the day when the fortunate English, French, Russians, Germans and Americans, raising banners and taking up mridangas and karatalas, will begin kirtana in the streets of their cities! When will that day come? Oh, the day when fair-skinned people from distant lands, joining the Bengali devotees, will sing: 'Jaya Shachinandana, jaya Shachinandana ki jaya!'" ("Sajjana-toshani," 1885, pp. 4–5; the Lord's words — CB, Antya 4.126)

"Our Teachers" sees the fulfilment of this prophecy in Russia too: the Thakura, the book says, named it one of the first countries where people would accept the teaching of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu with all their hearts.

The "Sajjana-toshani" and the books

He began his principal works while living at Naral (Jessore district), in 1878–1881: the "Sri Krishna-samhita," the songs of the "Kalyana-kalpa-taru," and the monthly journal "Sajjana-toshani" — "The Delight of the Virtuous." An English edition of the journal appeared from 1883, at Barasat, and in 1885 he revived the journal[24]. In the pages of the "Sajjana-toshani" he first printed many manuscripts of the Gosvamis and his own articles about them. Thus in the journal's second year (1885) appeared his note "Determining the Years of the Six Gosvamis," compiled from the records of a certain Vaishnava; in the first and second years the articles "Sri Jiva Gosvami" and "Sri Jiva Gosvami Prabhu," in the eleventh "Shat-sandarbha," in the fourth "Etawah on the Bank of the Yamuna"; in the tenth and eleventh

years (1899–1900) Narahari Sarakara's "Bhajanamrita" with his commentary "Asvada-vistarini." In the conclusion of that commentary he shows the essence of the book: Mahaprabhu taught pure bhakti through the "Shikshashtaka," after His departure its teaching was distorted, and Narahari at His behest wrote the "Bhajanamrita" — on nama-bhajana free of offences under the shelter of sadhu and guru. In the article "Sri Sri Jiva Gosvami Prabhu" the Thakura calls Srila Jiva a pandita and knower of Vedanta equal to Sri Ramanuja, and the "Shat-sandarbha" a jewel; the dates of Srila Jiva's life that he obtained agree with the record of Vishvambharananda Deva-Gosvami. Unpublished works also remained after him: an article on Srila Rupa's dramas "Vidagdha-madhava" and "Lalita-madhava" (later printed by the journal "Gaudiya") and an English life of Srila Jiva in his own hand.

He tirelessly collected and copied manuscripts. From the gadi of Gopala Guru he took his paddhati, and copies of this book survive in his hand; an old manuscript of the "Nataka-chandrika" was also copied in his hand. In Vrindavana he himself copied the "Sat-kriya-sara-dipika" and the "Samskara-dipika" and printed them for the first time in the "Sajjana-toshani." From there too he brought Srila Rupa's "Upadeshamrita": the manuscript was given him by the pandit Banamali Lal Gosvami, and the Thakura in rapture placed it on his head. In 1898, in the journal's ninth year, he published it with the commentary "Prakashika" of Radharamana Dasa Gosvami and his own, the "Piyusha-varshini-vritti," signing himself "Bhaktivinoda-dasa, a resident of Godruma." His collection also held an old kadacha with the dates of Raghunatha Bhatta's life, and on it his note: "contradicts the panjika."

In all, from 1866 to 1907, he wrote and published a great many works in Bengali, Sanskrit, English and Urdu[25] ("Our Teachers" names Hindi as well). In them, this book says, he built a majestic edifice of Vaishnava culture: metaphysical doctrine, ritual and worship, social order, education, relations between religions and broad paths for a worldwide Vaishnava movement. In his youth these were English books and lectures — on the "Bhagavata" (1869), "Reflections," on the verses on Haridasa Thakura's samadhi, on the temple of Jagannatha and on the akhras of Puri (1871) — and an exposition of the "Garbha-stotra" (1870). Then came the Sanskrit "Vedantadhikarana-mala" (1872), "Datta-kaustubha" (1874), "Datta-vamsha-mala" (1876) and "Bauddha-vijaya-kavya" (1878). In 1880 the "Sri Krishna-samhita" appeared, in Sanskrit and Bengali, and in 1881 the "Kalyana-kalpa-taru."

The year 1886 was especially fruitful. Living in Serampore, he published the "Bhagavad-gita" with Srila Vishvanatha Chakravarti's commentary "Sarartha-darshini" and his own Bengali translation "Rasika-ranjana"; the "Sri Chaitanya-shikshamrita," a compendium of Mahaprabhu's teaching; the Sanskrit commentary "Sammodana" on the "Shikshashtaka"; the book "Bhaktivinoda"; a verse translation of Srila Raghunatha Dasa's "Manah-shiksha" with the commentary "Bhajana-darpana"; the "Dashopanishad-churnika," the "Bhavavali," the novel "Prema-pradipa," the "Vishnu-sahasra-nama" with Baladeva's commentary — and published the "Sri Krishna-vijaya"[26]. Srila Sridhar Maharaj said that in translating the "Gita" into Bengali the Thakura relied mainly on the commentaries of Srila Baladeva Vidyabhushana and Srila Vishvanatha Chakravarti. In 1887 the "Chaitanya Upanishad" came out with his commentary "Chaitanya-charanamrita": the manuscript of this upanishad was sent to him from Sambalpur by Pandita Madhusudana Dasa[27]. In the same year, now at Krishnanagar, he began the "Amnaya-sutra" and brought out the "Navadvipa-dhama-mahatmya"[28].

Then followed the "Vaishnava-siddhanta-mala" (1888), the "Sri Amnaya-sutra," the "Navadvipa-dhama-mahatmya" and a translation of the "Siddhanta-darpana" (1890), the "Bhagavad-gita" with Baladeva's commentary and the Bengali "Vidvad-ranjana-bhashya" (1891), five little books on the Holy Name — "Sri Harinama," "Sri Nama," "Sri Nama-tattva," "Sri Nama-mahima," "Sri Nama-prachara" — and "Sriman Mahaprabhura shiksha" (1892). In 1893 — the "Tattva-viveka," the songs of "Sharanagati" and "Shoka-shatana," and the "Jaiva-dharma," a narrative in which Mahaprabhu's teaching unfolds in living dialogues. In 1894 — the "Tattva-sutra," the "Ishopanishad"

with his commentary "Vedarka-didhiti" (later reissued by the Gaudiya Math), and the "Tattva-muktavali," or "Mayavada-shata-dushani." In 1895 the "Amrita-pravaha-bhashya" appeared — his commentary on the "Chaitanya-charitamrita." In 1896, returning from Tripura to Calcutta, he published the "Sri Gauranga-smarana-mangala-stotra" and the English book "Life and Precepts of Sree Chaitanya Mahaprabhu," as well as the "Sri Ramanuja-upadesha" and the "Artha-panchaka." According to "Our Teachers," the English book grew out of his commentary on the Sanskrit "Smarana-mangala-stotra," and the Thakura sent it to the libraries of many Western universities, bringing there the message of Sri Chaitanya.

In 1897 he translated the "Brahma-samhita" and revised the "Kalyana-kalpa-taru"; in 1898 he translated and explained the "Krishna-karnamrita" and the "Upadeshamrita," published the "Gita" with Madhva's commentary and, in two volumes, a Bengali translation of Srila Sanatana's "Brihad-bhagavatamrita"; in 1899 he translated Narahari Thakura's "Bhajanamrita" and wrote the "Navadvipa-bhava-tarangini." The year 1900 brought the "Sri Harinama-chintamani" — a book on the Holy Name — as well as the "Bhagavatarka-marichi-mala" and a translation of the "Sri Sankalpa-kalpadruma"; to these years also belongs the "Tattva-vamsha-mala." Then came an edition of the "Padma Purana" (1901), the "Bhajana-rahasya" and a revised "Vijana-grama about sannyasis" (1902), a new redaction of the "Sri Krishna-samhita" and an edition of the "Sat-kriya-sara-dipika" (1903), the enlarged "Sri Chaitanya-shikshamrita" and the "Prema-vivarta" (1905)[29], the Sanskrit "Sva-niyama-dvadashaka" (1906), a translation of and commentary on the "Sri Nimbarka-dasha-shloki," and the song collections "Sri Gitamala" and "Sri Gitavali" (1907). Early works — a book in Urdu, "Balid-e-registry," the speech on Gautama and the Bengali verses "Hari-katha" — are dated as far back as the 1850s.

Godruma

On 4 October 1894 Srila Bhaktivinoda retired, settled at Surabhi-kunja in Godruma, and continued his discourses on the shastras there. In July 1896, at the invitation of the independent Raja of Tripura, Birchandra Devavarma Manikya Bahadur, he went with his son to Agartala and charmed the raja with talks on bhakti. In the same year he took his son to Kurseong, in the Himalayan foothills, and in October 1898 to Kashi and Prayag; on the way back they visited Gaya.

In Godruma-dvipa, by the river Sarasvati, he set up a new place of bhajana — Svananda-sukhada-kunja[30] — and performed his bhajana there. Srila Gaurakishora Dasa Babaji came here constantly to hear the Thakura read the "Bhagavata" and to talk about Vaishnava teaching; his renunciation deeply moved the Thakura. Here in 1898 Srila Bhaktisiddhanta first saw his future guru, and in the month of Magha 1900, at his father's behest, received from him initiation (bhagavati-diksha) and the name Varshabhanavi-dayita Dasa; after that, following his father's example, he visited Kashi, Prayag and other tirthas.

In March 1900 Bhaktivinoda and his son came to Puri by way of Balasore and Remuna, where they had darshana of Kshira-chora Gopinatha, Bhubaneswar and Sakshi-gopala. The son wished to perform bhajana at the samadhi of Haridasa Thakura on the seashore, and his father arranged with the sub-registrar of Puri, Jagabandhu Pattanayak, for the son to be entrusted with the service of the Giridhari-asana in the Satasan Math. In March 1901 the Thakura came to Puri again, and in 1902 began building his own dwelling by Haridasa Thakura's samadhi — the "Bhakti Kuti." Nearby, in a tent on the shore, there lived at that time the Raja of Cossimbazar, Manindra Chandra Nandi, mourning someone close to him; he often heard Bhaktivinoda and his son and received instruction in bhakti from the Thakura. When the son met with difficulties in the service of the Giridhari-asana and with attacks, the Thakura advised him to leave for Mayapur and perform bhajana in seclusion, as Sri Ramanuja once did at Tirunarayanapura.

In 1903 Srila Bhaktisiddhanta regularly read and expounded the "Chaitanya-charitamrita" in the "Bhakti Kuti" in his father's presence. The Thakura was visited by the well-known Radharamana Charan Dasa Babaji; they discussed the teaching, and Srila Bhaktisiddhanta showed from the shastras that his conduct and teaching departed from the true tradition. In Navadvipa Bhaktivinoda introduced his son to Vamshidasa Babaji. And Charan Dasa Babaji, with Vishnu Dasa of Kalna and others, once went with Srila Bhaktisiddhanta in kirtana to Mayapur on Dola-purnima, and the next year announced to Bhaktivinoda that he wished to lead a party round Navadvipa-dhama every year. He also wished to take part in the Navadvipa parikrama begun by the Thakura, but died before he could, in 1906.

The Thakura's house was open to everyone who wished to speak with him, and he was glad of every opportunity to explain Sri Chaitanya's teaching. Once a well-known sahajiya babaji came to him, and the Thakura received the guest and began an unhurried conversation with him. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta came into the room to bow to his father, but, seeing him with the babaji, bowed from a distance and went out. The guest was surprised: "Why did this dear young man not join our conversation?" The Thakura answered: "He has taken a vow never to come closer than a hundred paces to a sahajiya. He could not break his oath."

"Prabhu" and "Vibhu"

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta honoured both his gurus — Srila Gaurakishora Dasa Babaji and Srila Bhaktivinoda — as non-different from Sri Rupa, and remembered them together already in the opening verses (mangalacharana) of his commentary "Anuvritti" on the "Upadeshamrita": "Gaurakishora Prabhu and Bhaktivinoda Vibhu preached pure bhakti…" Gaurakishora he called "Prabhu" — "my master" — and his father "Vibhu." A vibhu is a shiksha-guru who "expands" his body, full of unlimited knowledge and bliss, tasting only the joy of his own nature. He is a goshthyanandi, one whose joy lies in the company of devotees, and in our age the first founder and great authority of the preaching of pure bhakti; this joy in the fellowship of devotees is the very mark of a "vibhu." And in the introduction to his "Gaudiya Bhashya" on the "Bhakti-sandarbha" Srila Bhaktisiddhanta calls him one intoxicated with Krishna-rasa, a treasury of the glory of the Lord's servants: and in this lies his "vibhu" quality.

Bhaktivinoda is the chief restorer of the preaching of pure bhakti. Rejoicing in the company of devotees, he mercifully pointed out to souls their obstacles, vices and anarthas and in many ways warned those walking the path of bhakti; and Srila Gaurakishora, for all his seclusion, helped fulfil his cherished aim. By the desire of Mahaprabhu Himself he acted openly, for all to see, as a goshthyanandi preacher, fulfilling the Lord's cherished wish. Therefore Srila Bhaktisiddhanta coined the expression "Sri Bhaktivinoda-dhara" — "the current of Bhaktivinoda": through him the current of pure bhakti began to flow again in the Gaudiya sampradaya in our time. Yet a vibhu is anyone who draws the world into the service of Hari, and so both gurus are; Srila Bhaktisiddhanta gave them the names "Prabhu" and "Vibhu" only to show the difference in their pastimes.

To a superficial eye he seems a man who lived in worldly comfort, censured renunciation, and spoke courteously and sympathetically with those whose vow is domestic happiness — the very opposite of the penniless Gaurakishora. With such knowledge one understands neither of them. "Impartiality shines in the life of Thakura Bhaktivinoda and of my Prabhu," Srila Bhaktisiddhanta wrote in the "Sajjana-toshani": the two saints are made of one substance and by the will of one Lord began different pastimes, drawing the whole world into the service of Hari.

Srila Gaurakishora ate Ganga clay and raw rice, went about as a naked renunciant, and rejoiced in the pastimes of Radha-Govinda. And Thakura Bhaktivinoda drank plenty of milk, lived in mansions, slept on a bedstead with a good bed and wore costly clothes — and just as eternally rejoiced in the pastimes of the same Gandharva and Giridhari. His "renunciation" is the highest thirst for Krishna's pastimes; it is

the same as in Ramananda Raya and Pundarika Vidyanidhi, in the six Gosvamis and Lokanatha, in Srila Bhaktisiddhanta and Srila Gaurakishora. The eternally perfect renunciation of Bhaktivinoda, Gaurakishora and Sarasvati — for Krishna's happiness — is seen only by one who has "the eyes of bhakti." His words "Goloka shines in the home" were fulfilled in his own bhajana; but this is seen only by those whose "fleshly," distorted vision has been removed. There is a song of the Thakura's, "tyajiya shayana-sukha vichitra palanka…" — about giving up repose on a decorated bedstead; on hearing it sung, Srila Vamshidasa Babaji remarked: "You only sing…"

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta recalled: by past pious merit he had obtained Bhaktivinoda, who wished him nothing but good; "my Prabhu" often visited his father and sometimes stayed with him. Once, to teach a lesson to a would-be renunciant, Srila Gaurakishora took off his kaupina and came to the Thakura at Svananda-sukhada-kunja in a washed dhoti with a black border and a chadar. And it was Bhaktivinoda who mercifully showed Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Gaurakishora; and by Prabhu's mercy he in turn gradually came to revere Bhaktivinoda's extraordinary nature. So it is said: without Bhaktivinoda's mercy one cannot know Gaurakishora, without Gaurakishora's mercy one cannot understand Bhaktivinoda's superhuman nature, and without Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's mercy one cannot understand either. To see one who has taken shelter in the Lord is to "see Prabhu"; to see the same person as "expanding his body" is to "see Vibhu": so Radha expands Herself fully for Krishna's senses, so Kaviraja sees Nityananda. Gaurakishora and Bhaktivinoda are the diksha-guru and the shiksha-guru of bhajana of one non-dual knowledge; only their pastimes differ.

Once Bhagavati Devi, the Thakura's wife, Mata Thakurani of the "Bhakti Bhavana," revered by all, came with other servants of the Thakura to Kulia to bow to Srila Gaurakishora. "You have left the Thakura at home — why then have you come to Kulia?" the Babaji greeted them. "An intimate associate of Gaura has appeared in your house." And when Bhaktivinoda, enacting the pastime of illness, was living in the "Bhakti Bhavana," the Babaji sent a certain gosvami to him with the words: "Carry Bhaktivinoda on your head from Calcutta, this universe of maya, here, to the dhama." The gosvami conveyed to the Thakura the Babaji's request that he move to Navadvipa, and the Thakura sent the Babaji his blessing: may his hari-bhajana be crowned with success. More on these and other episodes — in the article on Srila Gaurakishora Dasa Babaji.

The last years

In 1906 he spoke at length on Mahaprabhu's teaching in the house of the zamindar Yatindranatha Ray Chaudhuri at Taki, fifty kilometres east of Calcutta. On 26 February 1906 he returned to Calcutta, and from there went to Svarupganj, in Godruma-dvipa, to his bhajana at Svananda-sukhada-kunja. There a certain Taraka Brahma Gosvami of Jessore asked him to accept his Deities of Radha-Madhava for the place of Mahaprabhu's appearance, and moved there with his family; but soon their conduct proved incompatible with what was proper, and they had to leave. On 29 April 1906 the "Sri Dhama-pracharini-sabha" assigned the temple five hundred rupees a year for the service of Sri Sri Radha-Madhava.

In 1908 Srila Bhaktivinoda accepted the guise of a renounced Vaishnava — a bhagavata-paramahamsa, the babaji's dress — so as to immerse himself entirely in the nectar of the confidential pastimes of Radha and Govinda. Later, in 1918, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta took sannyasa — among other reasons, to show the transcendental nature of the paramahamsa's dress worn by his gurus: Jagannatha Dasa Babaji, Sacchidananda Bhaktivinoda and Gaurakishora. Taking sannyasa on 7 March 1918, the day of Mahaprabhu's appearance, in Mayapur, he bathed in the Ganga, put on saffron cloth and humbly bowed before the pictures of his two gurus — Srila Bhaktivinoda and Srila Gaurakishora.

On 25 March 1910, again on Phalguni-purnima, the day of Mahaprabhu's appearance, Jagadisha Bhakti Pradipa, then still a householder, came to him in Mayapur, and five days later received initiation from him in Godruma. Another disciple was living with him at Svananda-sukhada-kunja at that time — Krishnadasa Babaji. His worldly name was Indrachandra, and he came from Chhatra (Narail, Jessore). Coming to Navadvipa in 1314–1315 of the Bengali era, he received pancharatrika diksha from the Thakura, and in Phalguna 1315 initiation as a babaji and the name Krishnadasa Babaji. At the Thakura's bidding he chanted the Name loudly day and night — but counting: so the Thakura taught protection against inattention. At the beginning of 1316 the Thakura sent him to Puri, where he stayed a year and a half; on his return he served the Thakura day and night until his departure, and on the day of departure performed all that falls to the first disciple. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta called him "the beloved servant of Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura": those faithful to the Thakura, pining for him, were consoled by seeing Krishnadasa. He departed in 1915, a year and two months after his master; his samadhi is at Svananda-sukhada-kunja, beside the Thakura's memorial.

The Thakura taught that one should always observe daiva-varnashrama-dharma — the divine, not the hereditary, order. According to the "Sat-kriya-sara-dipika" he gave the sacred thread to Jagadisha Bhakti Pradipa (later the sannyasi Bhakti Pradipa Tirtha Maharaja, a disciple of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta), Sitanatha Mohapatra Bhakti Tirtha, Vasanta Kumar Ghosh and Manmathanatha Ray. And at the same time he said: the present social varnashrama is distinct from the transcendental religion of exclusive devotion to Krishna and does not of itself lead one to surrender to the Lord; the highest teaching of the "Gita" is to give up everything connected with varnas and ashramas — that is, with identifying oneself with the body — and to develop the bhakti inherent in the nature of the soul; and scholars like Raghavachari do not understand the Gaudiya teaching of pure bhakti.

In 1910, at Svananda-sukhada-kunja, while working on the "Sva-niyama-dvadashaka"[31], he suddenly fell gravely ill. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta and close disciples gathered round, fearing that he was entering the eternal pastimes. Even when unable to walk, he wished to be carried on horseback from place to place — for the sake of preaching. Three years before his departure Srila Bhaktisiddhanta made a vow to his father: unworthy servant though he was, he would take up the highest good work — he would rout all teachings opposed to pure bhakti. The Thakura was pleased.

The descendants of Nityananda and other associates, seeking gain, had at that time taken the side of the smartas. Vishvambharananda Deva-Gosvami of Gopivallabhapura invited Bhaktivinoda to an assembly of hundreds of pandits at Balighai (Midnapore), convened to affirm orthodox positions. Bedridden, the Thakura sent in his place his son and Suresh Chandra Mukhopadhyaya.[32] The assembly met on 8–11 September 1911; among the scholars was Madhusudana Gosvami Sarvabhauma of the Radha-Raman Ghera in Vrindavana. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta read there a paper on the difference between a Vaishnava and a brahmana and astonished the assembly. A year later Madhusudana Gosvami came to the Thakura at the "Bhakti Bhavana" and proclaimed Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Bhaktivinoda's worthy successor in defending the Gaudiya sampradaya.

In 1913 Srila Bhaktisiddhanta began his commentary "Anubhashya" on the "Chaitanya-charitamrita" — as a supplement to his father's "Amrita-pravaha-bhashya" — and read him passages from it, giving him indescribable joy.

Departure

A few days before his departure the Thakura moved from Godruma to the Calcutta "Bhakti Bhavana." There, on 23 June 1914, on the amavasya of the month of Vamana (Ashadha) — the very day on which the Gaura-shakti Sri Gadadhara Pandita Gosvami departed — he entered the midday pastimes of Sri Sri Radha-Govinda at Radha-kunda. Vaishnavas honour him to this day on the same day as Gadadhara

Pandita. Six years later, on 23 June 1920, on the same tithi, his wife Bhagavati Devi, the revered Mata Thakurani, also departed.

The Moon of Godruma

After the Thakura's departure, in 1950, the journal "Gaudiya" printed for the first time his verses "Sri Godruma-chandra-bhajanopadesha" — "Instruction on Worshipping the Moon of Godruma," with the refrain "bhaja godruma-kanana-kunja-vidhum" — "worship the moon of the groves of Godruma." They call one to leave the home full of the spirit of Kali and worldly talk, to become intoxicated with the Holy Name and go to the nine-islanded forest of Gaura; to read of Gaura-Hari, to roll in the dust of the Ganga's bank, to remember the pastimes of Gaura and Gadadhara, to become their follower and to hear of them. They also recall the legends of Godruma: here the Lord freed a demigod imprisoned in the body of a crocodile in the Goradaha lake, and appeared in His golden form to Indra and Surabhi, pleased with their austerities.

Legacy

After his father's departure Srila Bhaktisiddhanta became editor of the "Sajjana-toshani." He wrote then in the journal that its aim was unchanged: the Thakura had entered the eternal pastimes, but by his blessing the journal would go on delighting the sadhus. He quoted the Thakura's lines from the "Kalyana-kalpa-taru" — "bhakti-badha jaha haite se vidyara mastakete padaghata kara akaitava…": "That learning which hinders bhakti, without guile trample underfoot; Sarasvati is dear to Krishna, her heart is bhakti to Krishna; in this lies Vinoda's wealth." Neither Bhaktivinoda nor Mahaprabhu, he wrote, tolerates words opposed to bhakti or compromising with it; Mahaprabhu's message spread over the world through Bhaktivinoda; service to Gaura's teaching in obedience to the guru is not different from service to Radha-Govinda; "be a servant of the followers of Svarupa and Rupa and always chant the Name." In January 1915 the press was moved to Vraja-pattana in Mayapur, in March the journal came out again, and in July the press moved to Krishnanagar, from where the journal and Bhaktivinoda's books were printed. Later Srila Bhaktisiddhanta dedicated to his father articles in the journal "Gaudiya" — "Nilachale Srimad Bhaktivinoda" ("Bhaktivinoda in Puri") and "Gaudachale Sri Bhaktivinoda" ("Bhaktivinoda in Bengal"). Already in his lifetime, at his request and that of Shishir Kumar Ghosh, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta compiled a Vaishnava encyclopaedia, travelling all over India for it.

By the wish of Bhaktivinoda and Jagannatha Dasa Babaji, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta opened at Srivasa-angana a sankirtana centre with the service of the Pancha-tattva, and in the house of Chandrashekhara Acharya installed the dancing Gaura and founded Sri Chaitanya Math. In November 1918 he opened in Calcutta the "Sri Bhaktivinoda Asana" (1 Ultadanga Junction Road, near the Pareshnath temple) — the centre was so named at the wish of Kunja Babu. Here on 5 February 1919, on the day of Srimati Vishnupriya's appearance, the "Vishva-vaishnava-raja-sabha" was revived; the newspaper "Amrita Bazar Patrika" wrote at the time that Bhaktivinoda had given it "a new impetus" thirty-three years before. On 27 June 1919 Srila Bhaktisiddhanta installed a murti of Bhaktivinoda at Svananda-sukhada-kunja in Godruma. At the "Bhaktivinoda Asana" the first month-long kirtana festival was held from 18 August to 18 September 1919, and on 6 September 1920 Guru-Gauranga and Radha-Govinda were installed there and the first Sri Gaudiya Math arose, the first branch of Sri Chaitanya Math.

On 1 November 1920 Srila Bhaktisiddhanta initiated Bhaktivinoda's disciple Jagadisha Bhakti Pradipa, who bore the titles "Vaishnava-siddhanta-bhushana" and "Sampradaya-vaibhavacharya." At the Purushottama Math in Puri he instituted an annual festival in memory of Bhaktivinoda and Gadadhara

Pandita, and in Madras, at the Sarasvata Asana, he instructed disciples from the Thakura's books. In 1929 he laid out in Mayapur Ishodyan — "the Lord's garden" — which Bhaktivinoda had desired.

The Thakura's memory continued to be honoured. On 3 April 1931 the "Thakura Bhaktivinoda Institute" opened in Mayapur — a high English school with a Vaishnava upbringing; later a junior school bearing his name was opened as well. In 1933 he was commemorated at a meeting in the London Gaudiya Math on 23 June and in the town hall of Krishnanagar on 16 June, where Srila Bhaktisiddhanta spoke on the "Bhagavata" (Khitipati Nath Mitra and Dinanath Sanyal Ray Bahadur presiding). At Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's behest Y. Jagannatham published a Telugu translation of the "Sri Chaitanya-shikshamrita"; radio programmes were broadcast for the day of the Thakura's appearance. On 6 November 1935 Srila Bhaktisiddhanta established at Radha-kunda his pushpa-samadhi and bhava-seva in the "Vraja-Svananda-sukhada-kunja." On 12 February 1936 the "Thakur Bhaktivinoda Research Institute" (Krishnanushilana-gara)[33] was opened, and on 19 June of that year the twenty-second anniversary of his departure was observed at Svananda-sukhada-kunja.

"The current flowing from Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura will never be stopped; redouble your efforts to fulfil his desires," Srila Bhaktisiddhanta used to say; the current that has passed through Svarupa, Rupa and Bhaktivinoda will never run dry. On the morning of his own departure he asked for the song "tuhun daya-sagara tarayite prani" to be sung — from Bhaktivinoda's Bengali rendering of the "Shikshashtaka." The Thakura's songs and books, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta taught, are of the same essence as Srila Narottama's songs; they should be carried through Bengal, Orissa and Assam; the "Sharanagati" was translated into Tamil and the "Sri Chaitanya-shikshamrita" into Telugu.

Srila Bhaktivinoda, says "Our Teachers," is the embodiment of Sriman Mahaprabhu's mercy: he strove to remove the many distortions introduced into His teaching and passed this mission on to Srila Bhaktisiddhanta. And Srila B. R. Sridhar Maharaj, marvelling at what Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami had achieved, said: "What Bhaktivinoda Thakura conceived, Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati Thakura began to put into practice. And we see that through Swami Maharaj, at the end of his life, this plan has been fulfilled so completely. We are happy, we are glad, we are proud of it!"

Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava Gosvami Maharaja told his disciples: nothing more is needed — translate Bhaktivinoda's books into the languages of the world: that is the highest good for people; all that the Gaudiya Math has achieved is built on his foundation. Srila B. R. Sridhar Maharaj wrote a commentary on the "Sharanagati," and Srila Madhava Maharaja advised a doubting Kamakhya to read the "Jaiva-dharma" — and the doubts vanished. The Thakura's shiksha-disciple Bhakti Ratna Thakura introduced the young Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri Maharaja to the "Sajjana-toshani."

The Thakura's researches live on in small things too: thus in Puri he identified the well of Paramananda Puri of which the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" speaks — west of Jagannatha's temple, beside the police station.

The praise of disciples

Two eminent disciples of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta composed hymns in his honour. Srila B. R. Sridhar Maharaj — in Sanskrit: "I worship Bhaktivinoda, the embodied potency of Gaura, the emperor of the knowers of the scriptures on bhakti, the treasury of the nectar of Radha's rasa." Srila Bhakti Vichar Jajabar Maharaja — in Bengali, in the song "bhakativinoda prabhu, daya koro more…" Having read Srila Sridhar Maharaj's Sanskrit verses in praise of Bhaktivinoda, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta said: "Now I am at peace: after me there will remain at least one who can present my conclusions — bhakti-siddhanta."

"Our Teachers" specifies that Srila Bhaktisiddhanta spoke so of the "Srimad-Bhaktivinoda-viraha-dashakam" (1936): the style and depth of the poem struck him, and he

said to his sannyasi disciples, Sripad Bhaktiyadava Gosvami Maharaj and Sripad Shrauti Maharaj: "It is Bhaktivinoda Thakura speaking through him." Sridhar Maharaj himself recalled that when he read the poem to his guru, the latter remarked: "You have chosen the style very well," and later said to Shrauti Maharaj: "…its author is Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura himself, who has manifested his work through him. To me this is perfectly clear"; and to Sriyukta Aprakrita Prabhu he said: "I am glad that my message will survive me — I see the siddhanta in this verse."

Jajabar Maharaja's song says: by Bhaktivinoda's mercy one obtains Srila Prabhupada — Bhaktisiddhanta, whom he out of compassion gave to the world; through his preaching the world learned that Chaitanya's birthplace is Mayapur; his hundred books — the "Sri Chaitanya-shikshamrita," the "Jaiva-dharma" and others — and the journal "Sajjana-toshani" are revered by all; he restored the almost lost pure bhakti. By his example he taught that Krishna may be worshipped both at home and in the dhama; he manifested the service of the Deities of Gadadhara and Gaurahari, seeing in Them Radha and Madhava; he studied the books of the Gosvamis and preached their teaching, supporting it with evidence. He is like Vyasa, who revealed the Puranas, and his son, Prabhupada Dayita Dasa, like Shuka. He appeared in Gaura-mandala, in the village of Birnagar; and the author of the song himself, the sannyasi Jajabar, by his mercy found a place at Ishodyan, in Mayapur, in the Bhagavata Math.

In 1936, for the twenty-second anniversary of the Thakura's departure, Srila Sridhar Maharaj wrote the "Srimad-Bhaktivinoda-viraha-dashakam" — ten verses of separation: "for twenty-two years the world has borne the burden of separation." In them the Thakura is Gaura-shakti itself, who appeared drawn by the piety of souls, the personification of Mahaprabhu's compassionate power; even the gods cannot exhaust his glory, and in one verse sound Krishna's words to the gopis from the "Bhagavata": "I will not be able to repay you equally even in the course of many lifetimes" (CC, Adi 4.180; SB 10.32.22). He was sent when the minds of the wise had been ruined by false dharma, yoga for enjoyment, the knowledge of the void, proud philanthropy and immorality in the guise of raga-bhajana. As the moon revives the herbs, so his appearance gave fruit to the shastras and joy to the Vaishnavas. By his books he showed how to preach bhakti, and the glory of the earlier acharyas, Ramanuja and others, does not compare with his, for he is the embodied ocean of prema. He bestows Krishna Himself and service in Goloka-Vrindavana — the nectar of service to Radha's feet, approved by Gauranga, realised by Svarupa, honoured by Sanatana, distributed by Rupa and tasted by Raghunatha and the rupanugas. At the end the author prays to be counted among the servants of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta.

In the "Srimad-Bhaktivinoda-dashakam," printed in the journal "Gaudiya" in July 1939, Srila Sridhar Maharaj glorifies him as the embodiment of Chaitanya's mercy, Gaura-shakti, dear to Jagannatha Prabhu and non-different from Gaurakishora. The Thakura gave the example of preaching the "Sri Nama-chintamani," revealed the glory of the name chanted without offences, uncovered the hidden place of Gaura's appearance — to the joy of the saints and the chagrin of the wicked — and, like Bhagiratha, brought down the Ganga of bhakti, carrying Chaitanya's message over the world; he glorified the guru and the Vaishnavas and set the example of chanting the Name. He is prayojana, the goal, while Gaurakishora is sambandha and Bhaktisiddhanta abhidheya[34]; his books are the "Chaitanya-shikshamrita," the "Sajjana-toshani," the "Harinama-chintamani," the "Jaiva-dharma." He is non-different from the Gaura-shakti Gadadhara and departed on the same day — the amavasya of the month of Ashadha.

Kamala-manjari

Srila Bhaktivinoda's eternal identity has been disclosed to the members of his spiritual family. He is the best of the followers of Sri Rupa-manjari, leader of the retinue of Lalita-sakhi, the first of Srimati Radhika's eight friends. In the songs of the "Kalyana-kalpa-taru" ("yugala-sevaya shri-rasa-mandale…")

he calls himself an unworthy maidservant of Lalita-sakhi and prays to be appointed to the service of the Divine Couple in the circle of the rasa. And in the song "Siddhi-lalasa" from the collection "Gita-mala" ("varane tadit, vasa taravali…") he reveals his name — Kamala-manjari, a maidservant of Sri Rupa-manjari: her body is the colour of lightning, her sari the colour of the starry sky, she is forever twelve and a half years old; her abode is Svananda-sukhada-kunja in Lalita's grove[35], where she sets the pattern of service to the Divine Couple.

1. This Krishnananda Datta, the raja in whose house Nityananda stayed, should not be confused with his namesake Krishnananda Datta, the father of Srila Narottama Dasa Thakura.

2. By the Gregorian calendar — Sunday, 2 September 1838; by the lunar calendar — the shukla-trayodashi of the month of Bhadra, in the 352nd year of the Gauranga era (Gaurabda). Our Vaishnava calendar marks the day as the Gaura-trayodashi of the month of Hrishikesha.

3. This is a story of a child's search for truth, not a judgement on the Deity. For a Gaudiya Vaishnava the Deity of the Lord (archa-avatara) is not different from the Lord Himself, Who has descended out of mercy for His devotees; Srila Bhaktivinoda served Deities all his life — Giridhari, Kurma, Gaura-Gadadhara — while the scriptures distinguish the images of demigods, worshipped for worldly ends, from the Deities of Vishnu.

4. "Our Teachers" says that he grew up in Ula and graduated from the college in Krishnanagar, and in another place — that he graduated from the Scottish Church College in Calcutta. According to another biography, he studied at the Krishnanagar College only as a child, and in Calcutta at the Hindu School.

5. According to one of the biographies — in Bhowanipore.

6. "Our Teachers" calls Dvijendranath the elder brother of Maharshi Debendranath Tagore; in fact Dvijendranath Tagore (1840–1926) was Debendranath's eldest son.

7. The biography is unclear about the order of this journey: on one reading he visited his grandfather on the way back, on another on the way from Calcutta, going on from there to Puri.

8. The details are told differently: in some accounts the cord was wound about the body, in others about the shoulder; in some the annaprashana was performed with Jagannatha's prasada, in others with the prasada of Vimala Devi, whence the child's name. By the Bengali calendar — 25 Magha 1280 (1795 of the Shaka era).

9. In one account the chariot stood before the house for three days and the baby took the Lord's garland himself; in another, while the chariot stood on the Bada-danda, Bhagavati Devi at the Thakura's direction went up onto it with her son, he stretched his hand towards Jagannatha's feet, and the garland fell of itself upon his head.

10. So according to most of the biographies; according to one, the first meeting took place in Vrindavana during the journeys begun in 1877, without an exact year.

11. The year and address are given differently: in one account the house was begun in 1882 at 181 Maniktola Street; in another, in 1881 in Ram-Bagan; a third names the street "Manikarala Street."

12. In one place the biography calls Madan Mohan Datta Bhaktivinoda's great-grandfather, but by the genealogy it gives itself he was his grandfather's great-grandfather.

13. In another account his son received harinama and the Nrisimha-mantra in Serampore, when his father, returning from Puri, gave him a tulasi-mala of Jagannatha.

14. The biography dates this to 1885 and links it with the four-hundredth anniversary of Mahaprabhu's appearance; but the Lord appeared in 1486, and the four-hundredth anniversary falls in 1886. So too elsewhere in the same book: the World Society of Vaishnavas was founded in 1885, and a year later it celebrated the four-hundredth anniversary.

15. Elsewhere the same biography says that he helped found the "Vishva-vaishnava-raja-sabha" in the Durga-mandapa of Rama Gopala Basu in 1886. As the first founders of the sabha tradition names either Srila Jiva Gosvami (so the newspaper "Amrita Bazar Patrika" wrote in 1919) or Sri Rupa and Sri Sanatana; Srila Bhaktisiddhanta set out its history in the "Sajjana-toshani."

16. This book places the discovery in 1895; according to another biography, the Thakura saw the radiance in 1887 from the roof of the dharmashala at Kulia, across the river, the Babaji pointed out the place of appearance in March 1893, and the Deities were installed on 21 March 1894.

17. In another account the Babaji told Bhaktivinoda to build a hut for devotees beside his bhajana-kutira, and he built it.

18. So Bhaktivinoda himself writes; according to one of the biographies, the Babaji was then over a hundred and fifty years old.

19. The biographies give the year of this meeting differently: 9 March 1892, 1892 without a date, and 1891.

20. 20 Phalguna 1299 of the Bengali era corresponds to March 1893; one of the biographies gives the year 1892 with this date.

21. One of the biographies calls this day a Friday; by the calendar 21 March 1894 was a Wednesday.

22. This is a story of self-sacrifice in service, not an approval of bad habits: so that the service of the Deity in the newly discovered dhama should not be interrupted, the Thakura gave up his own good name.

23. Elsewhere the same biography places the Babaji's departure in February 1896.

24. The beginning of the journal is dated differently: by the list of works — 1881 (running to 1898); by the account of his life at Naral — 1878–1881.

25. The list of works given in one of the biographies opens with the words "from 1866 to 1907," yet includes writings of the 1850s: the book "Balid-e-registry" and the speech on Gautama (1856) and the verses "Hari-katha" (1850). In the account of his life the speech on Gautama belongs to the time of his service in Chhapra.

26. The biography names Satyaraja Khan as its author; but according to the "Chaitanya-charitamrita" the "Sri Krishna-vijaya" was written by his father, Gunaraja Khan: "Gunaraja Khan has a book, the 'Sri Krishna-vijaya,' in which there is one saying filled with the greatest love for Krishna" (CC, Madhya 15.99).

27. So according to our translation of the "Chaitanya Upanishad" and the edition itself: the manuscript was sent from Sambalpur by Pandita Madhusudana Dasa (by tradition, in 1886), and the book was printed in 1887 in Calcutta, at the "Bhakti Bhavana." Bhaktivinoda himself, in the colophon of the commentary, writes that he composed it "on the bank of the Jahnavi" "in the fourth century of the era of Sri Chaitanya" (that is, from 1886), and the colophon of the Bengali translation calls Madhusudana "a resident of Sambalpur." One of the biographies writes that Bhaktivinoda received the manuscript while himself serving at Sambalpur and calls Madhusudana his disciple; Bhaktivinoda's own words do not confirm this.

28. By the list of works the "Navadvipa-dhama-mahatmya" appeared in 1890.

29. So by the list of works; the first known edition of Jagadananda Pandita's "Prema-vivarta," brought out by Bhaktivinoda, is held to be the Calcutta edition of 1906 (by other lists, 1905).

30. The years are given differently: according to one biography, Svananda-sukhada-kunja was founded in 1897; according to another, the plot for it was bought in 1899. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's first meeting there with Srila Gaurakishora belongs to 1898.

31. By the list of works the "Sva-niyama-dvadashaka" was written in 1906.

32. According to "Our Teachers," it was Sri Madhusudana Gosvami, a well-known religious thinker, who asked Srila Bhaktisiddhanta to enter the debate, knowing of the Thakura's wish to expose the ideas of caste publicly.

33. In the list of maths in the same biography the year is given as 1931.

34. This is a play on words: "bhakti-vinoda," "the joy of bhakti," is the highest goal (prayojana), love of God; "gaura-kishora," the relationship with the youthful Gaura (sambandha); "bhakti-siddhanta," "the doctrine of bhakti," the means (abhidheya).

35. In one place the biography also calls this abode "Vrajananda-sukhada-kunja."